Introductions

There are a variety of ways to write introductions and with practice you can develop a formula that works for you. For the purpose of this document, the opening salutation and subject will be included as part of the introduction.

Salutation: If the name of the person is included in the case notes then it should be used. This can be followed by either a comma or full colon.

- Dear Dr. Wilson,
- Dear Dr. Wilson:

If the name of person is not mentioned then you can begin with Sir/Madam

- Dear Sir/Madam,

Subject: The subject is a place where information such as the name & age of the patient can be included. This can save you words in the body of the letter, but be careful not include too much information here, and definitely no phrases or sentences. Both Re & RE are acceptable.

- Re: Dylan Charles D.O.B. 04/12/2009
- RE: Dylan Charles D.O.B. 04/12/2009

Handy Tip 1

You can save on word length by added some detail after Re, such as the patient name and age. However, take care not to write too much here, and always use note form i.e nouns only (no articles, verbs, adjectives)

Basically, the introductory sentence of the letter can contain the following:

1. Background information such as name, age, occupation, marital status and gender of the patient if relevant and not mentioned in the subject line
2. A brief summary of the chief complaint, purpose of writing or your main concern

It will usually be only 1 or 2 sentences long and detailed information about the patient's history and condition should go in the main body of the letter**.**

Important Grammar Rules

The important patterns to learn are as follows:

Example 1

Relative Clauses: A relative clause is a useful sentence structure to use in the introduction. It allows the write to demonstrate the ability to write a complex sentence, which is a basic necessity to get B grade of higher.

1. I am writing to refer this patient. He is due to be discharged today. He has made a full recovery.
2. I am writing to refer this patient who is due to be discharged today after making a full recovery.

Example 2

Appositives: This is a noun or a noun phrase that is placed after another noun to explain or identify it, and a comma is required to separate these nouns. It has a very important use in the introductory sentence of referral letters as in the example below.

1. I am writing to refer Mr. Barry Booth. He is 68 years old. He is a pensioner. He is a widower. He requires dietary advice after undergoing heart surgery.
2. I am writing to refer Mr. Barry Booth, a 68-year-old widowed pensioner who requires dietary advice after undergoing heart surgery.

Example 3

Age: There are specific rules regarding how to refer to a patient's age. The first is that it must be hyphenated when used before a noun such as man/woman, and the second is that an article is required. For more details refer to Year Vs Years in the Grammar and Vocabulary Clinic.

Incorrect	Correct
• I am writing to refer this patient, a 63 years old man who lives alone. • I am writing to refer this patient, 63 years old man who lives alone.	• I am writing to refer this patient, a 63-year-old man who lives alone. • I am writing to refer this patient who is 63 years old and lives alone.

Handy Tip 2

Mastery of the patterns above will ensure that you start your letter on a positive note.

Sample Introductions

Introduction	Analysis
Dear Ms. Attard,	• Does not include patient name as this is clearly stated in the subject

Re: Ms. Robyn Harwood DOB: 04/02/1948 I am writing to request daily home visits by the Blue Nurses to provide care and support for this patient, a 61-year-old widow who lives on her own.	line • Uses relative clause and appositive sentence structures which demonstrate ability to use complex sentences • States purpose of writing clearly
Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Mr. Henry O'Keefe I am writing to request aged care assistance for Mr. O'Keefe, an 83-year-old man who is recovering from a malignant melanoma in his left shoulder.	• Includes shorter for a patient name as full name stated in the subject line • Uses appositive and relative clause sentence structure which demonstrates ability to use complex sentences • States both purpose of writing and chief complaint
Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Mr. Bill O' Riley I am writing with regard to Mr. O'Riley, a 53-year-old man who was admitted the hospital on the 2nd of September and diagnosed with obstructive coronary artery disease. He underwent a coronary artery bypass graft on the 4th of September.	• Includes shorter for a patient name as full name stated in the subject line • Uses appositive and relative clause sentence structure which demonstrates ability to use complex sentences • Summarises chief complaint and treatment
Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Mrs. Carol Bradley I am writing to request a respite admission for this patient, a 41-year-old married mother of two who has been receiving personal care from our organisation over the last two months.	• Does not include patient name as this is clearly stated in the subject line • Includes relevant biographical detail: age, marital status, mother • Uses relative clause and appositive sentence structures which demonstrate ability to use complex sentences • States purpose of writing clearly and summarises recent history
Dear Parents: Re: Outbreak of headlice	• Purpose of writing stated clearly in the subject line • Informs parents of main problem • Summarises symptoms and

I am writing to inform you of a recent outbreak of headlice at Mt Gravatt Primary School. Although headlice spread easily and cause several symptoms of itchiness and discomfort, they are easy to diagnose and treat.	treatment briefly
Dear Mrs. MacDonald, Re: Nasser Ali DOB: 04/02/62 I am writing to refer this patient who was admitted to our Coronary Care Unit ten days ago with the diagnosis of myocardial infarction. A cardiac artery bypass graft was done, followed by post- operative treatment and physiotherapy. Mr. Ali's condition has now stabilized and he is being discharged today.	• Does not include patient name or age as this is clearly stated in the subject line • States purpose of writing clearly and summarises recent history • Summarises chief complaint and treatment and current condition • Uses relative clause structure which demonstrate ability to use complex sentences
Dear Dr. Thompson, Re: Ms. Amber Watson DOB: 25/03/1991 I am writing to request further testing and contraceptive advice for this patient, an 18-year-old single woman who presented to our clinic for a Pap test on 16th May.	• Does not include patient name or age as this is clearly stated in the subject line • States purpose of writing clearly • Uses relative clause and appositive structures which demonstrate ability to use complex sentences

Common Errors

Incorrect	Correct
Dear Ms. Jones, Re: Mr. Adrian Lamp DOB: 10/10/1949 I am writing to refer Mr Adrian Lamp to you, an 61-year-old widower. He is due to be discharged today. He has made a full recovery from chest congestion. **Explanation:** No grammatical errors, but it lacks sophistication in the use of simple	Dear Ms. Jones, Re: Mr. Adrian Lamp DOB: 10/10/1949 I am writing to refer this patient to you, a 61-year-old widower who is due to be discharged today after making a full recovery from chest congestion.

sentences. Also, it repeats the patient name in full which is not necessary and repetitive since it was written directly above in the subject line.	
Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Beryl Saunders Thank you for admitting Mrs. Saunders, an 80-year-old dementia patient,requires respite care for a period of two months. **Explanation**: Relative pronoun required.	Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Beryl Saunders Thank you for admitting Mrs. Saunders, an 80-year-old dementia patient who requires respite care for a period of two months.
Dear Mrs. Smith, I am writing in regards of Annette MacNamara , single, age pensioner, requesting your assistance when she discharged from this hospital today. **Explanation**: Several errors in terms of sentence structure and grammar.	Dear Mrs. Smith, I am writing in regards of Annette MacNamara , a single age pensioner who will require your assistance when she discharges from hospital today. **or** I am writing to request assistance for Annette MacNamara , a single age pensioner who is due to be discharged from this hospital today.
Dear Doctor, Re: Mrs Diana Atherton I am writing to refer Mrs Atherton, a 77 year old woman who is a resident at the Sandy Beach Retirement Village, who needs urgent admission to your hospital due to chest pain. **Explanation**: Incorrect sentence structure with two relative clauses.	Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Mrs Diana Atherton I am writing to refer Mrs Atherton, a 77-year-old woman who is a resident at the Sandy Beach Retirement Village. She needs urgent admission to your hospital due to chest pain. **or** I am writing to refer Mrs Atherton, a 77-year-old female resident at the Sandy Beach Retirement Village who needs urgent admission to your hospital due to chest pain.
Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Aiden Cooper I am writing to refer Cooper a 12-year-old	Dear Sir/Madam, Re: Aiden Cooper I am writing to refer Aiden, a 12-year-old

boy, who is a year 6 student at Wellers Hill State School. **Explanation**: Two errors 1. Use first name when referring to a child. Click here for more details. 2. Incorrect comma placement	boy who is a year 6 student at Wellers Hill State School.

Study Strategy

When writing introductions, find a style which you like and use it for all tasks. However, take care to understand the basic grammar rules and always remember to include the chief complaint, purpose of writing or your main concern. Practice writing introductions using the sample case notes provided in your course.

Body Paragraphs

Most referral letters will contain 2 or 3 body paragraphs located between the introduction and the conclusion. Each of the paragraphs should have a main idea which the writer needs to convey to the reader. All the sentences with the paragraphs must relate to this main idea. The length of the paragraphs will vary, but an approximate guideline to meet the required word length of 180~200 words in OET is as follows:

- Introduction: 25 words
- Body paragraph 1: 40 words
- Body Paragraph 2: 40 words
- Body Paragraph 3: 70 words
- Conclusion: 25 words

Paragraph Structure

A good paragraph will contain 3 main elements

1. A Topic Sentence which introduces the reader to the main idea of the paragraph. In many cases it will identify and/or summarise an area of concern regarding the patient. Quite often it is written in original words rather than from words in the case notes.
2. Supporting sentences which may contain the detail regarding patient history, descriptions of symptoms, significant aspects from the treatment record, causes and effects, trends and so on. Quite often this information can be taken directly from the case notes, and written as full sentences. However, you will need to paraphrase the information into your own words. This includes:
    - Changing verbs to nouns: complain=complaint
    - Changing adjectives to nouns: lethargic=lethargy
    - Using synonyms
    - For more details on how to paraphrase, follow this link: Paraphrase
3. Signal words link sentences together so that the information flows smoothly and is easy to read.

Common signal words which can help you present information clearly and logically include:

- Time: *At that time, On review today, On consultation today, Recently, Over the past 3 weeks...., Two weeks later, On her next visit, During, Since that time, Initial examination..., On 19/08/10...*

- Location: *During hospitalisation, Initial examination at my clinic revealed...,On examination....*
- More information: *In addition, Moreover, Also, Apart from this..*
- Contrast: *However, Despite, Although*
- Result: *Therefore, Consequently, As a result, For this reason...*
- Emphasis: *Please note, May I remind you, My main concern is...., What concerns me most is.....*
- Sympathy: *Unfortunately, Regrettably, Fortunately,*
- Subject: *In terms of her social history..., With regard to her medication....,Based on the blood test results....., Regarding her medical history....., Her dental history shows..., The risk factors include....., Treatment to date includes...*
- Advice: *It is important to..., I recommend that you....., Please ensure that....*
- Chronology: *Firstly, Secondly, Finally*

Example 1

Case Notes	Paragraphs	Analysis
Diagnosis Right partial rotator cuff tear Presented to Mater hospital with pain and weakness in the right shoulder, especially when lifting arm overhead. Descending stairs at home and slipped, falling onto outstretched arm. Xray and MRI showed a partial rotator cuff tear. Orthopaedic surgeon discussed surgery. Patient prefers to try non-surgical treatment. Date of admission: 30-10-2008 Date of discharge: 01-11-2008	*Ms. Harwood was admitted to our hospital on the 30th of October with a diagnosis of right rotator cuff tear following a fall while descending stairs. Therefore, surgery has been suggested, however, she prefers non-surgical treatment. She has received ibuprofen and cortisone as prescribed and also daily visits by a physiotherapist.*	• Topic sentence is introduced with the phrase: *Ms. Harwood was admitted to our hospital on....* • Supporting sentences transform case notes into complete sentences • Signal words express cause and effect and express contrast ○ Therefore, ○ However

Treatment Ibuprofen orally QID Cortisone injections Daily physiotherapy		
Medical History Diabetes Mellitus Type 2 Metformin 500mg mane **Nursing Care Needs** Needs blood glucose level monitoring 4 hourly May be elevated because of cortisone Needs assistance with shower and housework Orthopaedic review on 19th November	*In terms of her medical history, she suffers from type 2 diabetes mellitus for which she is taking metformine 500mg. However, following her discharge, she will need a regular monitoring on the blood glucose level which may become elevated due to administration of cortisone during hospitalisation. She will also require assistance in showering and home help. As well as this, she needs to review her condition with an orthopaedic surgeon on the 19th of November.*	• Topic sentence is introduced with the phrase: *In terms of medical history,* • Supporting sentences transform case notes into complete sentences • Signal words connect ideas and express contrast ○ However, ○ due to ○ also ○ As well as this,
Social Background Marital status: Widow. No children. Lives alone Next of kin: Megan Mack (Niece) Niece lives with husband in Sydney who works as software engineer for Google Australia. Sister died recently. No other relatives.	*Ms. Harwood lives alone and has no children. Her next of kin is her niece, Megan Mack who lives in Sydney. Regrettably, she has no relatives or friends to support her.*	• There is no topic sentence, but the main idea of social history is clear • Supporting sentences expand the case notes into complete sentences, note the use of verbs, articles and conjunctions (and) • Signal word shows empathy ○ Regrettably,

Example 2

Case Notes	Paragraphs	Analysis
Birth History Normal vaginal birth at term Birth weight: 3400gm Apgar score at 5min: 9 No antenatal or postnatal complications **Feeding** Breast fed for first three weeks after birth. Baby became unsettled during heatwave at Christmas. Mother got sick and had a fever for a few days. Mother-in-law came to visit and advised changing baby to formula feeds. Mother-in-law advised extra powder in formula feeds to improve weight gain. Mother-in-law says her son (Ray Charles) also had feeding problems and difficulty gaining weight as a baby. Mother says she is worried she does not have enough breast milk and now gives extra formula feeds	*The patient was born via vaginal birth at term with a birth weight of 3400 grams. During a heatwave at Christmas, the baby became unsettled, due to lack of fluids. When the mother became sick for a few days, her mother-in-law visited to help out but has advised her to change to formula feeds and to put more powder in the bottle to improve weight gain. However, the mother believes that breast milk is the best for her baby and would like to breast feed full-time but is worried that she doesn't have enough breast milk for the baby. Therefore, she has been giving extra formula feeds to the baby.*	• The topic sentence is begins with the baby's birth. • Supporting sentences transform case notes into complete sentences • Displays understanding of the long case notes by summarising the main idea. Explains conflicting views of mother and mother-in-law. • Signal words express a time line, contrast and cause and effect. ○ During a heatwave ○ When... ○ However,.... ○ Therefore,....

as well as breast feeding. She wishes she could breast feed properly as she believes it would be the best thing for her son. He hasn't taken to the bottle.		
15/01/10 **Subjective** Mother and baby attended for routine 6 week check-up. Mother says she is concerned about constipation: once every three days, hard stool. Mother is asking about stool softener or prune juice for baby. **Objective** Reflexes normal Lethargic No abdominal tenderness Heart Rate: 174 Respirations: 56 Temperature: 37.1 Weight: 4200gms 3 wet nappies in last 24 hours. Urine dark. **Assessment** Mild constipation and dehydration	*At the 6 week check-up, the baby's weight is 4200 grams and his vital signs are in normal limits. However, the baby is suffering from mild constipation, dehydration and lethargy.*	• Topic sentence is introduced with the phrase: *At the 6 week check up,* • Focuses on objective information and final assessment.Omits less relevant detail. • Summarises objective details concisely into "vital signs in normal limits" • Paraphrases adjectives into nouns i.e lethargic=lethargy
Plan Increase breast feeds. Refer to breast	*Could you please support and advise the mother regarding*	• Topic sentence is a request of support • Supporting sentences expand

feeding support service. Check formula is correctly prepared. If continuing formula feeds, advise to supplement with water (boiled and cooled). Advise on keeping baby cool in hot weather. Return for review in 48 hours.	*breastfeeding and correct preparation of formula feeds if required. <u>In addition</u>, advice on how to keep the baby cool in hot weather is necessary. <u>Please note</u>, the patient is due for review on 17/01/2010.*	case notes into formal sentences • Signal words add cohesion ○ In addition, ○ Please note,

Conclusions

The conclusion or final paragraph in the letter should be fairly standard in structure. It should be based on the task question which is found at the end of case notes. It may contain one or two of the following points:

- a polite request of action required
- a thank you for ongoing support
- an offer of future assistance if required (this can be useful if you choose to omit some details from the case notes)

It is useful to be familiar with some standard patterns so that you are able to conclude your letter confidently, quickly and most importantly, accurately. However, some degree of originality will impress the assessors. Therefore, where possible try to ensure that your conclusion is related to your task and not simply a memorised ending.

Important Grammar Rules

Modal Verbs : Some modal verbs & the verb *hope* are used to convey politeness and commonly used for polite requests in the conclusion of formal letters. Compare the patterns below.

Informal	Polite	More polite
• Can you examine and treat the patient as you feel appropriate • I will be pleased if you can examine, diagnose and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. • Can you arrange someone to help this family and provide proper medical support.	• Please examine and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. • Please examine, diagnose and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. • Please arrange someone to help this family and provide proper medical support.	• Could you please examine and treat the patient as you feel appropriate • I would be grateful if you could examine, diagnose and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. (active) • I would appreciate it if you could examine, diagnose and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. (active) • It would be greatly appreciated if you could examine,

Explanation: These sentences are fine in spoken English, but not suitable for formal writing. *Can* and *will* are considered less polite than *could* and *would*.	**Explanation:** These sentences are acceptable in written English, but can sound quite direct.	diagnose and treat the patient as you feel appropriate. (passive and most polite) • I hope you can arrange someone to help this family and provide proper medical support. **Explanation:** These sentences are the most suitable for concluding requests in formal letters.

Conditional Sentences: These sentences are also frequently used in the conclusion of a referral letter and the rules are as follows:

Use a comma when the *if clause* is at the beginning of the sentence.	**Don't use a comma when the *if clause* is at the end of the sentence.**
• If you could take over her on going care,it would be greatly appreciated. • If you have any further questions regarding this patient, please don't hesitate to call me.	• It would be greatly appreciated if you could take over her ongoing care. • Please don't hesitate to call me if you have any further questions regarding this patient.
• If you require any more information, please don't hesitate to contact me.(active) • If any more information is required, please don't hesitate to contact me.(passive)	• Please don't hesitate to contact me if you require any more information.(active) • Please don't hesitate to contact me if any more information is required.(passive)
• Should you have any further queries, please don't hesitate to contact me. **Note:** Sometimes *if* is omitted from a conditional sentence. In full the sentence means: If you should have any further questions regarding this patient, please don't hesitate to call me.	• Please don't hesitate to contact me should you have any further queries.

Closer and signature

Leave a space between the last line of the conclusion and the closer. The closer should be followed by a comma. Then write your signature below the closer, and if you have time, print your name below your signature.

Sample Conclusions

Case Notes	Conclusion	Analysis
Writing Task Mr O'Riley has requested advice on low fat dietary guidelines and healthy simple recipes. Write a letter to the Community Information Section of the Heart Foundation, Gregory Terrace, Brisbane on the patient's behalf. Use the relevant case notes to explain Mr O'Riley's situation and the information he needs. Include Medical History, Body Mass Index and lifestyle. Information should be sent to his home address.	*In order to maintain a good health condition, Mr. O'Riley has requested advice on low fat dietary guidelines and healthy simple recipes. It <u>would</u> be greatly appreciated if you <u>could</u> send the above mentioned information to Mr. O'Riley at his home address, 9476 Old Dam Road, Goondiwindi, QLD, 4390.* *Yours sincerely,* *Lee Wong Charge Nurse*	• Uses information from the writing task to formulate conclusion • Contains a polite request • Maintains polite tone through the use of modal verbs would and could • Contains information specific to the task
Writing Task Using the information in the case notes, write a letter to The Director, Community Child Health Service, 15 Pauline Street, Kuraby, requesting follow-up of this family.	*<u>I hope you</u> will be able to arrange someone who can help this family and provide proper medical support. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you require any further information about this family.* *Yours sincerely,* *Nurse*	• Uses information from the writing task to formulate conclusion • Contains a request using the polite expression: *I hope you will be able to*.. • Contains information specific to the task • Offers future assistance
Writing Task Write a letter for the admitting doctor of the	*<u>I would appreciate</u> your assessment and emergency management of*	• Uses information from the writing task to formulate

Medivale Hospital Emergency Department. Give the recent history of events and also the patient's past medical history and condition.	*this patient's condition.* *Yours sincerely,* *Night Nurse* *Sandy Beach Retirement Village*	conclusion • Maintains polite tone through the use of modal verb would • Maintains level of urgency appropriate to the situation
Writing Task Write a referral letter to the Dr Jane Thompson, Medical Practitioner at the North Fitzroy General Practice, requesting assessment of your patient' condition. Give the recent history of events and also the patient's past medical history and condition.	*It would be greatly appreciated if you could assess the patient's condition and treat as you feel appropriate.* *Yours sincerely,* *Charge Nurse*	• Contains a very polite request using conditional "if" plus passive form • Polite tone through the use of modal verbs would & could • Note, sometimes a brief conclusion is all that is required,.... or all that you will have time for! Although it is a memorised phrase, it is grammatically correct, concise and direct.
Discharge Plan Organise social worker and Meals on Wheels. (niece will visit at weekend to help with housework and shopping) Stitches to be removed and situation to be reviewed at Out Patient Department appointment - 10.30 am 31-05-09 **Writing Task** Using the information in the case notes, write a letter to the Director, Blue Nursing Service, 207 Sydney	*It would be greatly appreciated if you could do daily home visits and provide support and reassurance for Mrs. Butler. In addition, please organize Meals on Wheels and a social worker for home help. Please note, the patient has an appointment at the Out Patient Department at 10.30 am 31-05-09 for the removal of stitches . Thank you for your ongoing care.*	• This is a long conclusion, but incorporates discharge plan into the conclusion which is an effective strategy • Emphasises a future appointment • Maintains polite tone through the use of modal verb would & could • Contains a polite

Street, West End.	*Yours sincerely,* *Charge Nurse*	thank you

Common Errors

Incorrect	Correct
• I would very much appreciated your attention regarding further management of Mr. Henderson. **Explanation:** Incorrect grammar, see above	• I would very much appreciate your attention regarding further management of Mr. Henderson.(active) • Your attention regarding further management of Mr. Henderson would be very much appreciated.(passive)
• If you have any query, please do not hesitate to contact me. **Explanation**: Use plural form of query	• If you have any queries, please do not hesitate to contact me.
• I will appreciate your further assessment and management **Explanation**: Polite form "would" required	• I would appreciate your further assessment and management.
• Kindly investigate this child and do the needful. If you need any more information regarding her situation, please try to contact me without any hesitation. **Explanation**: Several errors here. Basically it is important that the standard patterns and style conventions are followed in conclusions.	• I would appreciate it if you could investigate this child's condition and do the necessary management. If you require anymore information, please do not hesitate to contact me.
• Thanks to review and arrange a home visit for this patient, if you have any further questions, please be free to ask me.	• I would appreciate it if you could review and arrange a home visit for this patient. If you have any further questions, please do not hesitate to contact me.

Explanation: As above, several errors here. The style is casual and therefore an inappropriate way to conclude a letter	• It would be appreciated if you could review and arrange a home visit for this patient. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you have any further questions.
I would be appreciated if you could take over the care of this patient. **Explanation**: Incorrect grammar	• It would be appreciated if you could take over the care of this patient. (passive verb) • I would be appreciative if you could take over the care of this patient.(be + adjective) • I would appreciate it if you could take over the care of this patient. (active verb)

Handy Tip

As with introductions, when writing conclusions, find a style and pattern which you are confident with and use it. However, take care to understand the basic grammar rules and always remember to respond to the task question. Practice writing conclusions using the sample case notes provided in your course.